

Perseid Meteor Shower: Shooting Stars [B2]

A metà agosto di ogni anno, la Terra attraversa la scia della cometa Swift-Tuttle e migliaia di frammenti di roccia e ghiaccio entrano nell'atmosfera, provocando un sorprendente spettacolo di stelle cadenti.



Dreamers and amateur astrologists should look to the night sky in mid August. The Perseid [meteor shower](#) will [light up](#) the heavens, in a [dazzling](#) display of [shooting stars](#). They are visible for several weeks, but they will be brightest on certain nights. With the [moon setting](#) around midnight, the sky will be dark enough for viewing. The [pre-dawn](#) hours offer the best conditions to watch the show — and perhaps to make a wish.

ROCKS AND ICE

So what is a meteor, exactly? It is not actually a star, but rather a piece of space [debris](#) falling down to Earth. It comes from the [rubbletrailing](#) behind a comet, consisting of rocks and ice. While in space, it is called a ‘meteoroid’ and, once on the ground, it is called a ‘meteorite’ but, while it travels through our skies, it is a [plain old meteor](#). When the Earth passes through a comet’s trail, these particles enter the atmosphere, where they burn up and display [streaks](#) of light.

ELUSIVE COMET

The Perseid meteors come from the Comet 109P/Swift-Tuttle, which is in a 122-year orbit around the Sun. The comet itself was last seen in 1992 and will not be seen again until 2125, but its long trail of [debris](#) produces a [meteor shower](#) every year. Its next pass in a hundred years’ time is predicted to be as bright as Comet Halle-Bob in 1997, which was the brightest in recorded history.

WHAT’S IN A NAME?

Swift-Tuttle is a very large comet. At 26km in diameter, it is twice the size of the one that supposedly killed the dinosaurs. The comet was named after two scientists — Lewis Swift and Horace Tuttle — who separately discovered the comet in 1862. The meteors’ name derives from the constellation Perseus, after the [eponymous](#) hero from Greek mythology. Perseus lies in the northern sky, in the shape of a [sideways Y](#). Every year, it provides the [backdrop](#) of the Perseid shower.

WHEN AND WHERE

This year promises to be quite spectacular, with up to a hundred meteors per hour visible during the peak. According to NASA, they will travel at 59 kilometres per second, reaching temperatures of 1,650° C. The Perseids are best seen in areas with minimal light pollution, so the countryside or a park are ideal. [Stargazing](#) apps will help to locate the right place to look. [Avoid](#) looking at your phone and allow your eyes to adjust to the darkness. Then [lie on your back](#), watch the show and, [if you are so inclined](#), [wish upon a star](#).

Glossary

- **rubble** = macerie
- **plain old meteor** = meteora ordinaria
- **streaks** = strisce
- **eponymous** = eponimo
- **Stargazing** = osservazione delle stelle
- **if you are so inclined** = se sei propenso
- **pre-dawn** = prima dell'alba
- **lie on your back** = sdraiarsi sulla schiena
- **wish upon a star** = esprimere un desiderio
- **meteor shower** = sciame meteorico
- **shooting stars** = stelle cadenti
- **light up** = illuminare
- **debris** = detriti
- **trailing** = strascicare
- **sideways Y** = i greca di lato
- **backdrop** = sfondo, scenario
- **Avoid** = evitare
- **dazzling** = abbagliante
- **moon setting** = tramontare della luna